

Sijia “Leslie” Huang

huangs92@rowan.edu | sijiahuang.github.io

EDUCATION

Rowan University **Glassboro, NJ**

Doctor of Philosophy in Clinical Psychology (APA accredited, emphasis on integrated healthcare and health psychology) Expected Graduation: May 2029

Dissertation: Relationship Enrichment: The Feasibility and Acceptability of an Online Couples'

Program Using Sensate Focus Sex Therapy

Mentors: D.J. Angelone, Ph.D. and Meredith Jones, Ph.D.

Columbia University, Teachers College

New York, NY

Master of Arts in Psychology in Education: General Psychology

May 2024

New York University Shanghai

Shanghai, China | New York, NY

Bachelor of Arts in Social Science (Psychology Track)

May 2022

Minor in Humanities

HONORS & AWARDS

Student Researcher Travel Grants for 2026 Conference in Porto, Portugal 2026

International Academy of Sex Research

Outstanding Pre-Candidate Clinical Doctoral Student Award 2026

Rowan University, Department of Psychology

Graduate Student Travel Fund (\$600) 2024

Rowan University, School of Graduate Studies

Graduate Student Scholarship (\$3,000) 2022 – 2023

Columbia University Teachers College

Deans' Undergraduate Research Funds (\$1,000) 2021

NYU Shanghai

Dean's List for Academic Years 2020 – 2022

NYU Shanghai

Global Elite Scholar (¥120,000, approx. \$17,850) 2018 – 2022

NYU Shanghai

PEER-REVIEWED PUBLICATIONS

First Authored: 6, h-index: 5, Citations: 88 (per [Google Scholar](#))

1. **Huang, S.**, Yang, J., & Santtila, P. (2025). After the Act: After-Sex Behaviors and Their Correlates in Straight Chinese Couples. *Sexes*, 6(3), 48. <https://doi.org/10.3390/sexes6030048>
2. Li, Z., **Huang, S.**, & Santtila, P. (2025). Sexual communication in Chinese heterosexual couples: the efficacy of online Sensate Focus intervention and correlations with relational and sexual outcomes. *Sexual and Relationship Therapy*, 40(3), 564–592. <https://doi.org/10.1080/14681994.2025.2506090>
3. **Huang, S.**, Wang, Y., Li, G., Hall, B.J., & Nyman, T.J. (2024). Digital Mental Health Interventions for Alleviating Depression and Anxiety During Psychotherapy Waiting Lists:

Systematic Review. *JMIR: Mental Health*. 2024;11:e56650 doi: [10.2196/56650](https://doi.org/10.2196/56650)
PMID: [39255015](https://pubmed.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/39255015/).

4. **Huang, S.**, Li, Z., & Santtila, P. (2024). The effectiveness of online sensate focus exercises in enhancing sexual function and intimacy among Chinese heterosexual couples: a randomized controlled trial. *Journal of Sex & Marital Therapy*, 50(6), 707–724. <https://doi.org/10.1080/0092623X.2024.2355229>.
5. Eschliman, E. L., Hoang, D., Khoshnam, N., Ye, V., Kokaze, H., Ji, Y., Zhong, Y., Morumganti, A., Xi, W., **Huang, S.**, Choe, K., Poku, O. B., Alvarez, G., Nguyen, T., Nguyen, N. T., Shelley, D., & Yang, L. H. (2024). A “What Matters Most” approach to investigating intersectional stigma toward HIV and cancer in Hanoi, Vietnam. *Journal of the National Cancer Institute Monographs*, 2024(63), 11–19. <https://doi.org/10.1093/jncimonographs/lgae002>.
6. **Huang, S.**, Nyman, T.J., Jern, P., & Santtila, P. (2023). Actual and desired masturbation frequency, sexual distress and their correlates. *Archives of Sexual Behavior* 52, 3155–3170. <https://doi.org/10.1007/s10508-023-02641-3>.
7. **Huang, S.**, Jern, P., Niu, C., & Santtila, P. (2023). Associations between sexually submissive and dominant behaviors and sexual function in men and women. *International Journal of Impotence Research*, 37, 224–232. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s41443-023-00705-5>.
8. **Huang, S.**, Niu, C., & Santtila, P. (2022). Masturbation frequency and sexual function in individuals with and without sexual partners. *Sexes* 3, 229–243. <https://doi.org/10.3390/sexes3020018>.

MANUSCRIPTS UNDER REVIEW AND IN PREPARATION

1. **Huang, S.**, Santtila, P., Angelone, D.J., & Jones, M. C. [Under review] Online Sexual Interventions in Enriching Couple’s Sex Life: A Narrative Review.
2. **Huang, S.**, Jones, M. C., Angelone, D.J., Jern, P., & Brunwasser, S. M. [Under review] Sexual dysfunction as a predictor of sexual violence perpetration among Finnish men and women.
3. Baker, S., John, J., **Huang, S.**, Angelone, D.J., & Jones, M. C. [Under review] Different Instruments, Different Answers: Incongruent Sexual Violence Reporting Across Common Measures.

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

1. **Huang, S.**, Jones, M.C., Angelone, D.J. (2026, July. 14). *Relationship Enrichment: The Feasibility and Acceptability of an Online Couples' Program Using Sensate Focus Sex Therapy*. Poster to be presented at the 52nd annual conference of the International Academy of Sex Research; Porto, Portugal. Awarded for Student Researcher Travel Grants.
2. Angelone, D.J., Mitchell, D., Wells, B.E., Korovich, M., Bettinelli, M., **Huang, S.**, & Shirley, J. (2025, Nov. 14). *Examining factors influencing sexual violence risk perception in men who have sex with men on dating and sexual networking Apps*. Symposium presented at the annual conference of the Society for the Scientific Study of Sexuality; Philadelphia, PA. [CE credit]
3. **Huang, S.**, Korovich, M., Angelone, D.J., Mitchell, D., & Wells, B.E. (2025, Nov. 14). *Associations between sexual self-esteem, dating motives, and risk perception*. Paper presented at the annual conference of the Society for the Scientific Study of Sexuality; Philadelphia, PA.

4. **Huang, S.**, Shank, F., Korovich, M., Arigo, D., Jones, M., & Angelone, D.J. (2024, Nov. 16). *Associations between college sexual hookup behavior and eating disorders*. Poster presented at the annual conference of the Society for the Scientific Study of Sexuality; San Diego, CA.
5. Li, B., **Huang, S.**, Daneils, L., Cai, B., Phillips M., & Yang, L.H. (2024, Aug. 8). *Demographic and clinical characteristics of Chinese schizophrenia patients assessed by MCCB*. Poster presented at the 2024 American Psychological Association Conference, Division 40 – Society for Clinical Neuropsychology. Seattle, USA.
6. **Huang, S.** & Santtila, P. (2023, Aug. 8). *The effectiveness of online sensate focus exercises in enhancing sexual function and intimacy among Chinese heterosexual couples*. Poster presented at the 49th annual conference of the International Academy of Sex Research; Montreal, Canada.
7. **Huang, S.** & Santtila, P. (2023, Apr. 28). *Can online sensate focus exercises enhance sexual and relationship satisfaction among Chinese heterosexual couples?* Poster presented at the 6th annual conference of the Institute of Psychological Science and Practice at Columbia University Teachers College. New York, USA. Awarded for Outstanding Poster.
8. **Huang, S.** & Santtila, P. (2021, Nov. 6). *How does sexual dysfunction relate to relationship and sexual satisfaction among Chinese adults?* Poster presented at Fall 2021 Undergraduate Research Symposium. NYU Shanghai, China. Awarded for Best Research Project in Liberal Arts & Business.
9. **Huang, S.** & Santtila, P. (2020, Dec. 14). *How Do Chinese Parents Perceive Sex Education Program at Elementary Schools?* Poster presented at Fall 2020 Empirical Research Practice Symposium. NYU Shanghai, China.

Clinical Experience

Practicum Extern at Cooper University Hospital Camden, NJ

Behavioral Medicine Consultation-Liaison (Supervisors: Kelly Gilrain, Ph.D., Anastasia Bullock, Psy.D., Alexa Hays, Ph.D., Sarah Fishman Ph.D., Corey Doremus, Ph.D.) Jul 2026 – Present

- Provide bedside assessments, consultations, and brief interventions including CBT, ACT, and mindfulness-based strategies at inpatient hospital.
- Consults span major medical departments, including Trauma, Oncology, Cardiology, Surgery, OB-GYN/NICU, Pediatrics/PICU, General Medicine, and Emergency Medicine.
- Common concerns include adjustment to illness or injury, pain, cognitive dysfunction, end-of-life issues, treatment-related stress, and mobilizing social supports.
- Collaborate closely with multidisciplinary teams, offering psychological insights and recommendations to address emotional and cognitive challenges related to medical conditions.

Practicum Extern at Cooper University Hospital Camden, NJ

Integrated Ambulatory Care (Outpatient Rotation)
in the Center for Comprehensive Health (Supervisor: Michael DeAngelo, Psy.D.) Jul 2025 – Jun 2026

- Provided outpatient psychotherapy to patients with HIV or other chronic infectious diseases, presenting depression, anxiety, trauma-related symptoms, psychosis, insomnia, behavioral and/or substance use problems.
- Facilitated smoking cessation group therapy to help patients who are quitting smoking cigarettes and vapes.
- Utilized evidence-based treatments, including CBT, mindfulness, trauma-informed approaches, and motivation interviewing.

- Conducted initial clinical interview, neurocognitive and psychodiagnostic assessments.
- Assisted inpatient consult for newly admitted patients who are HIV+ to cope with hospitalization.
- Assisted gender-affirming assessment for transgender patients who are preparing for medical or surgical transition treatments.
- Participated in weekly behavioral medicine didactics, case presentation, and group supervision.
- Attended multidisciplinary treatment team meetings with physicians, nurses, case management, and navigation to collaborate on patient care.

Student Counselor for Cognitive Processing Therapy (CPT), NYU Shanghai **Shanghai, China**
(PI: Gu Li, Ph.D.) Feb 2023 – Feb 2025

- Provided online feedback for Chinese gay men who are going through adapted CPT intervention, under the supervision of licensed psychologist Dr. Thomas Nyman.
- Coded the accuracy of self-identified maladaptive thoughts and propose thought-challenging questions.

RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

ASSeRT Lab, Rowan University

Glassboro, NJ

PhD Student (PI: D.J. Angelone, Ph.D. and Meredith Jones, Ph.D.)

Aug 2024 – Present

Lab website: <https://www.rowanassert.com/>.

Primary Projects:

1. Relationship Enrichment: The Feasibility and Acceptability of an Online Couples' Program Using Sensate Focus Sex Therapy (REFOCUS)
 - Write, develop, and manage IRB protocols for REFOCUS.
 - Build pre-, post-, and follow-up questionnaires, as well as intervention videos using REDCap.
2. Sexual Dysfunction and Sexual Violence Perpetration Study
 - Conducted research on sexual dysfunction, trait anger, and sexual violence perpetration.
 - Successfully defended thesis titled “Sexual Dysfunction as a Predictor of Sexual Violence Perpetration among Finnish Men and Women” on October 22 2025, for Masters of Arts in Clinical Psychology.

Secondary Projects:

1. Barriers of Engaging in Healthcare among Young Moms
 - Lead a qualitative study about young moms’ experiences in healthcare, code interview transcripts, identify themes, conduct thematic analysis, and write manuscript.
 - Mentor a coding team of 5 students.
 - Assist a qualitative study about providers’ experiences in working with young moms in the healthcare system, code interview transcripts and discuss with the team to identify themes.
2. Intoxication and Aggression Study
 - Assist The Manhattan Project, investigating the impact of alcohol intoxication on male aggression in laboratory paradigms.
3. Mentor Experience
 - Mentor 4 undergraduate students and provide training in literature review, article presentation, participants recruitment, and data cleaning using syntax in SPSS.

Sex Research, NYU Shanghai

Co-Investigator (PI: Pekka Santtila, Ph.D.)

Shanghai, China

Oct 2020 – Aug 2024

Sensate Focus Sex Therapy Study

- Completed IRB application, including a Randomized Control Trial study protocol, subsequent amendments, and annual reports.
- Developed 11 animation videos demoing Sensate Focus Exercises, based on the sex therapy model proposed by Masters and Johnson.
- Pre-screened 1,231 Chinese participants for Sensate Focus intervention through three waves, assessing sexual dysfunction, relationship and sexual satisfaction, and sexual script.
- Facilitated the longitudinal experimental intervention, post-test, and three months follow-up assessments with 19 couples in the experimental group, 24 couples in the waitlist control group.
- Employ various statistical analyses in SPSS and R, including syntax, Pearson Correlation, Independent-Sample *t*-test, Paired-Sample *t*-test, Cronbach's alphas Reliability test, ANOVA, ANCOVA, Repeated Measures, and Linear Mixed-effects Model.

Masturbation, Sexual Distress, and Sexual Function Study

- Analyzed data on masturbation frequency and related sexual distress from a Finnish population-based datafile, including 12,271 participants that Dr. Santtila previously collected.
- Explored the correlated factors and etiology of sexual distress.
- Conducted statistical analyses in SPSS, including Chi-square, Linear Regression, and General Estimated Equations.
- Discussed implications of clinical diagnosis of compulsive sexual behavior, particularly problematic masturbation.

Paraphilia and Sexual Dysfunction Study

- Investigated the association between paraphilia, especially BDSM interest and related behavior, and sexual function among Finnish people.
- Combined and analyzed three data sets that Dr. Santtila and his colleagues previously collected, with 29,821 participants in total.

Sex Education in China Study

- Investigated Chinese parents' attitudes towards sex education, focusing on parents with children in elementary schools.
- Designed an online survey using Qualtrics and recruited 182 participants.
- Analyzed the correlation between parents' overall supportiveness of sex education and delivery method, specific teaching contents, and other statements about sex education.
- Performed in Professor Santtila's weekly research seminar from 2021 to 2022, collaborated with ECNU graduate student working on sex research, engaging in discussions covering a wide range of topics, including early ejaculation, ginger's impact on sex drive, obesity and sexuality, internalized homophobia, and the interplay between sexual arousal and the feeling of disgust.

Maternal and Reproductive Psychology Lab, Columbia University

Research Assistant (PI: Aurelie Athan, Ph.D.)

New York, NY

Feb 2024 – Jul 2024

- Completed training in Sex Education Initiative
- Assisted qualitative analysis about Reproductive Life Planning

Digital Mental Health, NYU Shanghai

Research Assistant (PI: Thomas Nyman, Ph.D.)

Shanghai, China

May 2023 – May 2024

- Conducted literature review on the effectiveness of digital intervention for people waiting for face-to-face therapy.
- Performed articles searching in PubMed, PsycINFO, Cochrane, and Web of Science.
- Developed study protocol and completed pre-registration in OSF.

- Completed abstract and title screening for 9267 articles using Covidence.
- Assisted full-text review for 23 articles and conducted data extraction.

Loss, Trauma, and Resilience Lab, Columbia University

New York, NY

Research Assistant (PI: George Bonanno, Ph.D.)

Feb 2023 – May 2024

- Investigated coping mechanisms in response to challenging life experiences, with a specific focus on individuals who engage in nonsuicidal self-injurious (NSSI) behaviors and those who do not.
- Managed the study email inbox and coordinated participants scheduling on a weekly basis.
- Assisted pre-data processing, including stamping, editing, and transcribing of the recorded interviews with the participants.

Culture, Stigma, and Psychosis Lab, Columbia University

New York, NY

Research Assistant (PI: Lawrence Yang, Ph.D.)

Oct 2022 – May 2024

Psychosis in China Study

- Conducted research on cognition across the lifespan in untreated psychosis in China.
- Reviewed 61 articles about MATRICS Consensus Cognitive Battery (MCCB), 45 in Chinese and 16 in English.
- Extracted data on 79 columns for each article.
- Assisted data cleaning and data extraction training for new research assistants.
- Led poster preparation for 2024 APA Conference, entitled “Demographic and clinical characteristics of Chinese schizophrenia patients assessed by MCCB.”
- Assisted in compilation of grant proposals via conducting literature reviews on the association between antipsychotic medications and accelerated aging, as well as mediators of cognitive deficits in schizophrenia.

Cancer, HIV, and Mental Health in Vietnam Study

- Examined stigma of cancer, HIV, and mental health in people living with HIV in Vietnam.
- Coded related qualitative data (i.e., interviews) based on the codebook.
- Assisted scale development for interview transcripts, discussed with others to come up with scale items based on the key qualitative themes, identified relevant quotes in the interviews.

TEACHING EXPERIENCE

Instructor, College of Science and Mathematics at Rowan University

- | | |
|---------------------------------|-------------|
| • Psychological Disorders | Fall 2026 |
| • Psychology of Human Sexuality | Spring 2026 |
| • Essentials of Psychology | Fall 2025 |

Learning Assistant, College of Science and Mathematics at Rowan University

- | | |
|----------------------------|-------------|
| • Physiological Psychology | Spring 2025 |
| • Abnormal Psychology | Fall 2024 |

MEDIA COVERAGE

1. **PsyPost**, Feb 2025, “Low user engagement limits effectiveness of digital mental health interventions.” <https://www.psypost.org/low-user-engagement-limits-effectiveness-of-digital-mental-health-interventions/>
2. **NYU Shanghai Center for Global Health Equity**, Nov 2024, “New Review Reveals Limited Effectiveness of Digital Mental Health Interventions for Individuals Awaiting Psychotherapy.”

<https://cghe.shanghai.nyu.edu/news/new-review-reveals-limited-effectiveness-digital-mental-health-interventions-individuals>

3. **PsyPost**, Nov 2023, “Study uncovers subtle links between BDSM practices and sexual well-being.” <https://www.psypost.org/study-uncovers-subtle-links-between-bdsm-practices-and-sexual-well-being/>
4. **PsyPost**, Oct 2023, “Large study unpacks the complicated nature of ‘problematic masturbation.’” <https://www.psypost.org/large-study-unpacks-the-complicated-nature-of-problematic-masturbation/>

LEADERSHIP & SERVICE

Student Involvement Co-Chair, *Board of Directors at the Society for the Scientific Study of Sexuality* Nov 2025 – Present

- Serve as the representative for student members within the organization and plan events to foster engagement, professional development, and increase networking opportunities.
- Attend board of directors’ meetings throughout the year to discuss committee ideas and advocate for student member needs.
- Plan and organize the annual scientific conference meeting, including special events exclusive for the student members.

Lab Coordinator, *ASSeRT Lab at Rowan University* Nov 2025 – Present

- Oversee day-to-day operations of the ASSeRT lab, including project management, data organization, and communication across 2 faculty, 5 doctoral students, 15 undergraduate students, and 2 post baccalaureate volunteers.
- Track all current research projects to maintain productivity, preserve project timelines, and facilitate clear communication across all researchers.
- Lead weekly leadership and lab meetings to meet research goals, track progress, designate tasks, and problem-solve any issues that arise.
- Coordinate research assistant recruitment and onboarding, including application review, interviewing, and intradepartmental communication.
- Manage administrative documentation and training materials to standardize lab procedures and improve research efficiency.

Orientation Ambassador, *Office of Student Life at NYU Shanghai* Apr 2021 – Oct 2021

- Served as a peer mentor for a group of 17 NYU Shanghai freshmen from 6 different countries.
- Hosted an informative session titled “Let’s Talk about Sex | Sexual Misconduct.”
- Facilitated 7 diversity and inclusivity dialogues for the group to foster a healthy community, discussing topics such as food, language, socializing, and resilience.
- Provided advice on life, academic, and career planning, supporting freshmen in transitioning smoothly to life at NYU Shanghai.

Student Worker, *Student Health Center at NYU Shanghai* Oct 2018 – May 2019

- Created articles about health and wellness using online platform Xiumi for WeChat Official Accounts, reaching an average of 200 out of 1200 viewers in the NYU Shanghai community.
- Designed weekly newsletter emails for the NYU Shanghai community using Mailchimp.
- Promoted lectures, events, workshops, and activities about health to encourage healthy lifestyles within the NYU community.

EDITORIAL EXPERIENCES

Peer Review for Academic Journals

- *Discover Social Science and Health*: 1 review in 2026
- *Journal of Sex & Marital Therapy*: 1 review in 2024; 4 review in 2025
- *Psychology, Health & Medicine*: 1 review in 2025
- *Nature Partner Journals (NPJ) Women's Health*: 1 review in 2024
- *BMC Psychiatry*: 1 review in 2024
- *BMC Women's Health*: 1 review in 2024

PROFESSIONAL MEMBERSHIPS

The Society for the Scientific Study of Sexuality	Jul 2024 – Present
American Psychological Association	Sep 2023 – Present
Psi Chi, The International Honor Society in Psychology	Feb 2023 – Present
International Academy of Sex Research	Jan 2023 – Present
American Association of Sexuality Educators, Counselors and Therapist	Jan 2023 – Present

GRANT APPLICATIONS

[External] Psi Chi Graduate Research Grants May 2026

Relationship Enrichment: The Feasibility and Acceptability of an Online Couples' Program Using Sensate Focus Sex Therapy

PI: Sijia Huang, M.A.

Faculty Mentors: Meredith Jones, Ph.D., and D.J. Angelone, Ph.D.

Amount Requested: \$1,500

Status: Under review

[External] International Academy of Sex Research: Le Shaw Micro Grant May 2026

Relationship Enrichment: The Feasibility and Acceptability of an Online Couples' Program Using Sensate Focus Sex Therapy

PI: Sijia Huang, M.A.

Faculty Mentors: Meredith Jones, Ph.D., and D.J. Angelone, Ph.D.

Amount Requested: \$1,000

Status: Under review

[External] American Psychological Foundation: Visionary Grant Apr 2026

Relationship Enrichment: The Feasibility and Acceptability of an Online Couples' Program Using Sensate Focus Sex Therapy

PI: Sijia Huang, M.A.

Faculty Mentors: Meredith Jones, Ph.D., and D.J. Angelone, Ph.D.

Amount Requested: \$5,000

Status: Under review

[External] The Society for the Scientific Study of Sexuality: Graduate Student Research Grant Mar 2026

Relationship Enrichment: The Feasibility and Acceptability of an Online Couples' Program Using Sensate Focus Sex Therapy

PI: Sijia Huang, M.A.

Faculty Mentors: Meredith Jones, Ph.D., and D.J. Angelone, Ph.D.

Amount Requested: \$1,500

Status: Under review

- [External] Society for Health Psychology: Graduate Student Research Awards** Jan 2026
Digital Sensate Focus: Evaluating an Animation-Based Sex Therapy Program
 PI: Sijia Huang, M.A.
 Faculty Mentors: Meredith Jones, Ph.D., and D.J. Angelone, Ph.D.
 Amount Requested: \$2,000
 Status: Not funded
- [Internal] Columbia University Teachers College Dean's Grant for Student Research** Nov 2022
Can Web-based Sensate Focus Exercises Enhance Sexual and Relationship Satisfaction?
 PI: Sijia Huang, B.A.
 Faculty Mentor: Pekka Santtila, Ph.D.
 Amount Requested: \$2,000
 Status: Not funded
- [Internal] NYU Shanghai Deans' Undergraduate Research Funds** May 2021
Can Web-based Sensate Focus Exercises Enhance Relationship Satisfaction?
 PI: Sijia Huang
 Faculty Mentor: Pekka Santtila, Ph.D.
 Amount Requested: \$1,000
 Status: Funded

PROFESSIONAL DEVELOPMENT

Sex Education Initiative at Teachers College	Feb 2024 – Mar 2024
Social Emotional Learning at ThinkHuman.TV	Sep 2023 – Dec 2023
Yale Psychology's Sneak Peek Program	Jul 2023 – May 2024
NextGen Psych Scholars Program (NPSP) at University of Minnesota	Jun 2023 – May 2024

SKILLS

Language: English (fluent), Mandarin Chinese (native), Sichuanese (native)
Data Analysis and Online Methods: R, SPSS, Eye-tracking (TOBII, Gazepoint, ELAN), Qualtrics, EndNote, Zotero, Covidence, Web design using Github and Squarespace